Part

The Exam

Exam Format

The VCE English exam is a three-hour exam, plus 15 minutes of reading time. It has three sections, and you are required to complete all three sections. Each section is worth the same number of marks, so you should spend the same amount of time on each.

Exam Specifications

Overall Conditions

- The examination will be sat at a time and date to be set annually by the Victorian Curriculum and Assessment Authority (VCAA). VCAA examination rules will apply.
- There will be 15 minutes of reading time and 3 hours of writing time.
- The examination will be assessed by a panel appointed by the VCAA.
- The examination will contribute 50 per cent to the study score.

Format

The Task Book will be sixteen pages in length. The front page contains the general cover notes and instructions, including rules about what you can and can't take into the exam.

An English and/or bilingual printed dictionary is permitted.

Mobile Phones and/pr any unauthrosied electronic devices are not permitted.

Specifications from VCAA:

- The examination will be in the form of a Task Book.
- The examination will consist of three sections.
- Section A will consist of an analytical response to a text and will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- Students will be required to write an analytical response to one of the two texts studied from List 1 of the VCE English and English as an Additional Language (EAL) Text List for the year in question. There will be two topics for each of the 20 texts on List 1. Students will be required to write a response to one topic on one text.

- Student responses should demonstrate knowledge and understanding of the text, its structure and the ideas, concerns and values raised by the topic, and support their response with close reference to the text. If the selected text is a collection of poetry or short stories, students may write on several poems or stories, or on at least two in close detail.
- The response will be assessed according to the assessment criteria specified on the following page.
- Section B will consist of creating a text and will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- Students will be required to create one written text. For the purposes of this task, a 'written text' does not include song, poetry or verse. In creating their text, students must use the title provided, relevant idea(s) from at least one unseen stimulus and be connected to one of the Frameworks of Ideas. The text must be developed with a clear purpose(s) – to explain, to express, to argue, to reflect – and should be an effective and cohesive piece of writing. Students should demonstrate fluency through the selection of vocabulary, text structure(s) and language features, and employ an appropriate voice in their text.
- The place of mentor texts is to provide access to ideas and inform the teaching of writing, but students will not be required to make explicit reference to them in the examination.
- The text will be assessed according to the assessment criteria specified below. Section B will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- Section C will consist of an analysis of argument and language and will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- Students will be required to analyse the use of argument(s) and language to persuade an intended audience to share the point of view expressed in an unseen persuasive text. For the purposes of this task, 'language' refers to written and spoken language, and 'visuals' refers to images and graphics. Students will not be required to evaluate the relative merits or successes of argument(s).
- The response will be assessed according to the assessment criteria specified below.
- Section C will be worth a total of 20 marks.

- The total marks for the examination will be 60.
- Answers to Section A, B and C are to be recorded in the Answer Book.

Exam Mindset, Timing and FAQs

How Your Paper Is Marked

Each section is marked by at least two assessors, each giving a score out of 10, combined into a mark out of 20. If the two scores are too far apart, a third (or further) assessor reads the response. Assessors mark holistically against the expected qualities, and always in relation to the topic or title. They read every word and reward as far as they can. In 2025 the average for each section sat around 5.4 to 5.5 out of 10.

Attitude Is a Predictor

An Australian study of students under test conditions, controlling for ability, found that attitude alone predicted results. “Confident striders” (prepared, and trusting that the test would be fair) did best; students who expected the test to be unfair and stressful tended to fulfil that prophecy. Practical takeaways:

- **Trust the paper to be fair.** Recent papers have been. A question may be phrased unexpectedly, but you are transferring skills you have practised to a new instance.
- **A little nerves is useful.** Adrenaline speeds thinking. Worrying about things you cannot control only takes up brain space.
- **Confidence comes from preparation**, not from hoping.

Habits of Successful Students

- **Train for three hours.** Do some study in three-hour blocks so the exam is not the first time you concentrate that long. Work out what breakfast keeps you going.
- **Practise, get feedback, act on it, practise again.**
- **Eat well, sleep, and exercise** to burn off anxiety when it tips from useful to unhelpful.
- **Have a backup plan.** No single exam decides your future. Missing a first-choice course often means a transfer a year later.

Time Discipline

The three sections are worth equal marks, so give each one hour. The first marks in any response are the easiest to earn. An extra half hour polishing one essay gains far less than the same half hour spent on the next. Use the room clock, and when the hour is up, move on.

Plan, Then Write

Planning is not extra work; it shifts the work. When you write without a plan, you are deciding what to say and how to say it at the same time, and your brain switches between the two and loses time. Plan first (only you need to read it), check it is relevant to the topic, then give your full attention to expression. Fluency is assessed in every section.

Frequently Asked Questions

- **How many quotes should I use in Section A?** There is no number. It depends on how many other kinds of evidence you use (structure, character, setting, language features, context), and every quote must be explained, not just included.
- **Should I memorise a strong practice response?** No, in any section. You cannot know the topic, title or text, and a memorised piece that does not answer the question cannot score highly.
- **Which section should I do first?** Personal choice. Some students do A, B, C in order; others start with whichever they plan fastest. Try different orders in practice exams.
- **What should I do the night before?** Put the books away and sleep. A year of preparation will not be changed by two more hours.
- **What if I make a mistake?** Cross it out neatly and keep going. If you realise mid-essay you have drifted, fix your topic sentences, but stay within your hour. Checking your plan early is the best prevention.
- **What if I don't get the score I want?** You get the score you get. It is a snapshot of one day, and your skills keep growing after it.

Strategies for Addressing the Requirements

Section A

In Section A you will write an essay that responds to one of the two given topics on a text you have studied. You can choose to write on either your Unit 1 text or your Unit 4 text. In your answer book you will need to identify the text on which you are writing and the topic (i or ii) you are responding to by shading the relevant box.

Spend a few minutes unpacking the topic you feel most comfortable responding to. Look carefully at each term in the topic and make sure you understand its meaning and significance. Use the strategies for identifying topic words, direction words and limiting words outlined on pages 48–50 in English Year 12.

Spend about 5 minutes writing a brief plan that includes your contention, three or four topic sentences and one or two pieces of textual evidence for each topic sentence.

The following strategies will help you to address the Section A requirements and criteria.

- Address the topic in full. Strong responses take account of every word in the topic, including the limiting words, rather than writing about one key term in a general way.
- Use your dictionary. Make sure you understand the meanings of all the words in the topic. Your dictionary will also give you some synonyms for key terms in the topic, and using these will give your writing more variety and precision.
- Consider a range of textual features. Don't limit your reasons and evidence to just what the characters say and do. While authors do use characters to explore ideas, they also use features such as narrative voice, structure, setting and imagery. Film techniques should be referred to when analysing a film, and an analysis of poetry will be enhanced by a consideration of poetic form and techniques. Discussing these features shows a deeper understanding of the text and a more sophisticated response to the topic.
- Integrate quotes and explain their significance. It is useful to include some direct quotes, as this is part of how you show your 'knowledge and understanding of the text' (criterion 2 for Section A). However, make sure you incorporate quotes into your discussion and thoroughly explain how they support the point you are making. If you

use a quote and then mention it on its own, or place it at the end of a sentence without further explanation, it will be unclear to your assessor how the quote helps to advance your argument.

- Write precisely and expressively. Develop a wide vocabulary during the year by creating word banks (see the examples on pages 58–63 of English Year 12) and use a variety of words in your practice essays, so by the time you sit the exam you can make effective vocabulary choices in all your responses.

Section B

In Section B you will write a text that responds to a given title and at least one piece of stimulus material. In the answer book, you will need to shade the box of your chosen Framework, and the box (or boxes) corresponding to the stimulus (or stimuli) you have responded to.

The following strategies will help you to address the Section B criteria and weave the stimuli and title into your creative piece.

- Ensure your writing is clearly relevant to your chosen Framework. This involves integrating concepts and perspectives that you've explored during the year. When you are revising in preparation for the exam, refer to your notes and written pieces to stay aligned with the core ideas of the Framework.
- Integrate the title and at least one stimulus into your writing. You must use at least one of the stimuli. The stimulus should not just be referenced superficially; it should be woven into the fabric of your piece. This could mean, for example, using a text stimulus as the basis for a central idea; using a text stimulus as a direct quote at a key point in your text; or drawing inspiration from a visual stimulus to set a scene. Similarly, the title provided for your Framework should provide an idea, a character arc, a central image or another key element of your writing.
- Give your piece cohesion and structure. Your piece should have a clear beginning, middle and end, regardless of whether it's a narrative, an argument or a reflective piece. Each part should seamlessly transition into the next, maintaining a logical flow of ideas.
- Make appropriate use of language, style and voice. The language and style of your writing should suit the purpose and audience. This includes choosing the most appropriate vocabulary, tone and sentence structures. In your Unit 3 drafts and

assessment pieces, you will have worked hard to develop your own unique voice. You likely have a preferred form of writing (fiction or nonfiction, story, article etc.) and you should lean into that during the exam.

- Write with fluency and expression. Your writing should read smoothly, with a natural flow of ideas and language. This can be achieved by varying your sentence structures, giving your writing a subtle rhythm and clearly articulating your ideas. Transitions between paragraphs or sections should be logical and easy for the reader to follow.

Section C

In Section C you will analyse a text in which the writer seeks to persuade a particular audience to agree with their point of view on an issue. The text will be primarily written but will also contain one or more visual elements.

This task has been part of the VCE English exam for many years and as part of your preparation you may use past exam papers as sources of practice material. In some cases you will find that the task material consists of more than one written piece, but the exam specifications for 2024–2027 indicate that there will only be a single 'unseen persuasive text' in the English exams during this period.

The following strategies will help you to address the Section C requirements and criteria.

- Understand the contention. What, essentially, is the writer saying? An accurate understanding of the writer's central argument underpins your analysis. Clearly state the writer's contention in your introduction.
- Read the background information carefully. This is where you will find out the intended audience and the context for the text. Your analysis will be strengthened by a consideration of how the writer's choices of argument and language are shaped by their particular audience and context (see the final bullet point below).
- Examine the sequencing of the argument. Writers will arrange their material and their points of argument in a particular order so as to engage their intended audience and influence their thoughts and feelings. Look at the overall shape of the argument, then drill down into the specific points and language choices. Shifts in tone are important aspects of the structure, too.
- Examine language choices. Writers make deliberate choices of words to add impact to their arguments and to evoke the audience's emotions. Identify words with strong

positive or negative connotations and associations and spend some time in your analysis 'unpacking' their likely effects on the audience. You will not have time to analyse every use of language in the text, but discuss a representative sample of language choices.

- Use effective verbs. In your analysis of a persuasive text, verbs enable you to describe what the writer is doing and how they are doing it. Repeating the verbs 'positions' and 'persuades' doesn't show your understanding of how argument and language are being used. Verbs such as 'reinforces', 'emphasises', 'instils', 'elicits' and 'undermines' can be used to show your understanding of how a writer is attempting to persuade. See the verbs in the activity on page 210 of English Year 12 for some other examples.
- Analyse how argument, language and visuals are working together. Don't treat these as separate elements of the text, since an audience's response will be a result of how all these elements are working in combination. Look at how language is used to present an argument, and how an image complements and reinforces particular reasons or pieces of evidence.